FREE GUIDE · UPDATED NOVEMBER 2026

Backups: keep your photos and documents safe

A computer can be repaired or replaced; family photos and documents cannot. A backup is a safety copy: it takes half an hour the first time, then it works on its own.

The 3-2-1 rule

- **3 copies** of your data: the original and two copies.
- **2 different media**: for example the computer's disk and an external drive.
- **1 copy away from home** or online: a cloud service, or a drive kept by a relative.

On Windows

Connect an external drive. In Control Panel open **File History** and press **Turn on**: Windows will copy documents, pictures, music and desktop by itself, every hour.

Windows 11 also has the **Windows Backup** app, which saves folders and settings to your Microsoft account (OneDrive, 5 GB free).

On a Mac

Connect an external drive and open **System Settings › General › Time Machine › Add Backup Disk**. The Mac makes hourly, daily and weekly copies by itself.

On Linux

Use the **Backups** app (Déjà Dup) or your distribution's backup tool: choose the folders to save, the external drive and how often.

On your phone

- **Android**: turn on backup in Google Photos and in the Google settings (15 GB free, shared with Gmail and Drive).
- **iPhone and iPad**: Settings › your name › iCloud › iCloud Backup (5 GB free), or a copy on your computer.

Three habits that make the difference

- Disconnect the external drive when the copy is finished: a virus cannot reach it.
- Every now and then, try to restore a file: a backup that won't open is no use.
- Put a monthly reminder in your calendar.

The right time to make a backup is before something happens. If you like, I'll set it up together with you.

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